

BuzzFeed A/B Testing Report: Newsletter Delivery Time & Website Header Update

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Date: June 2025

Overview

BuzzFeed conducted two distinct A/B tests to optimize newsletter engagement and subscription rates. The first test examined whether changing the newsletter delivery time from morning to evening would increase open rates. The second test evaluated the impact of a redesigned website banner on converting visitors into newsletter subscribers. Both tests were carefully analyzed to provide actionable insights aligned with BuzzFeed's growth and revenue goals.

1. Newsletter Delivery Time Test

Objective:

Evaluate if sending the newsletter in the evening instead of the morning results in a higher email open rate, thereby increasing opportunities for advertising revenue.

Hypotheses:

- **Null (H_0):** Evening delivery does not increase the open rate compared to morning delivery.
- **Alternative (H_1):** Evening delivery increases the open rate compared to morning delivery.

Methodology:

- Baseline open rate: 14%
- Desired increase in open rate: 17% (an absolute increase of 3%, which represents a **~22% relative increase**)

- Calculated **Minimum Detectable Effect (MDE)**: ~22% relative increase in open rate
- Recommended sample size per group to detect this MDE at 5% significance and 80% power: approximately **1,722 recipients**
- Actual sample sizes were 1,819 (morning) and 1,792 (evening), which **meet and slightly exceed** the recommended minimum.

Results:

- The sample sizes were sufficient to detect the targeted increase.
- The test showed a statistically significant increase in open rates for the evening delivery group.
- This supports sending the newsletter in the evening to improve engagement and revenue opportunities.

Pivot Table:

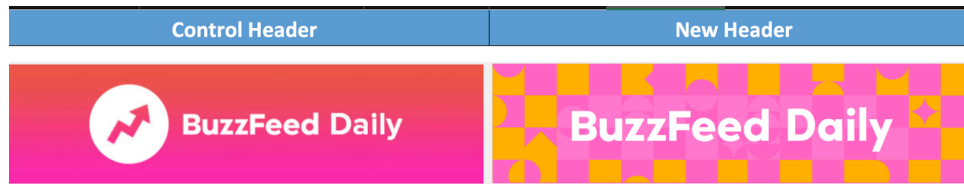
Row Labels	Count of Time of Day	Sum of Opened
AM	1819	260
PM	1792	293
Grand Total	3611	553

- Number of recipients in AM and PM groups
- Number and percentage of emails opened

2. Website Header Update Test

Objective:

Assess whether a redesigned website banner improves the conversion rate of visitors subscribing to BuzzFeed's newsletter.



Hypotheses:

- **Null (H_0):** The new banner does not increase the subscription rate compared to the existing banner.
- **Alternative (H_1):** The new banner increases the subscription rate.

Methodology:

- Control group included 4,881 visitors with 210 conversions (4.3% conversion rate).
- Test group included 4,956 visitors with 238 conversions (4.8% conversion rate).
- Sample sizes met the calculated threshold for detecting a 25% relative lift (from 4% to 5%) at 80% power and 5% significance.

Results:

- The observed increase in conversion rate was approximately 0.5 percentage points (12% relative improvement).
- However, the result was not statistically significant at the 5% level ($p \approx 0.11$).
- This means the evidence is insufficient to confidently claim the new banner improves subscription rates.

Additional Insight:

- The test was powered for detecting larger effects (25% relative increase), so the smaller observed increase may require a larger sample size for significance.
- The positive trend indicates potential, suggesting further testing or alternative banner designs could yield better results.

Pivot Table:

	# Converted	Total
Control	4881	210
New Header	4956	238

- Total visitors per group
 - Number of conversions
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Recommendations

- **Newsletter Delivery Time:** Implement the evening delivery schedule based on statistically significant improvements in open rates, which supports BuzzFeed's advertising and engagement goals.
 - **Website Header:** Do not implement the new banner broadly yet due to lack of statistical significance. Instead, extend testing with larger sample sizes or explore alternative designs to improve conversion rates effectively.
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Tools and Resources Used

- Sample size and MDE calculations: [Statsig A/B Test Sample Size Calculator](#)
 - Statistical significance testing: [Neil Patel A/B Testing Calculator](#)
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Conclusion

Both tests highlight the importance of rigorous experimentation and data-driven decision-making. While the delivery time change clearly benefits engagement, the header update requires further analysis. Continuing to iterate and test will ensure BuzzFeed optimizes newsletter performance and maximizes revenue potential.
